Zap it!

National Museum of American History, Smithsonian Institution

Oven-sized microwaves for the home were introduced in 1955, but not until the 1980s did shrinking sizes and prices attract buyers. Although manufacturers envisioned home cooks using microwaves to prepare traditional meals with all the trimmings, not many did. Instead, most households used the microwave to zap frozen foods, leftovers - and popcorn.

Objects described on the page

Product flier, 1955. Microwave oven, 1974. U.S. patent for the first popping bag, filed 1973.

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